



Basic Twi for Travelers

This is a brief introduction to Twi (pronounced “tchwee”), which is a language spoken in Ghana by about 7 million people. Twi is the most widely spoken of the Akan dialects – and Akan is spoken by about 45% of the Ghanaian population. Within Ghana, Twi is spoken in the Ashanti Region and in parts of the Eastern, Western, Central, Volta and Brong Ahafo Regions. This introduction contains basic instruction about pronunciation and important words and phrases. When volunteering and traveling in Ghana, the ability to communicate in Twi will greatly enhance your experience. Even if you do not plan on studying the language in-depth, we strongly suggest learning and using basic greetings and phrases. The locals will greatly appreciate your efforts and will be all the more welcoming to you during your stay. If you would like to complete a beginning course in Twi, there are a number of self-study books and tapes. Florence Abena Dolphyne’s *A Comprehensive Course in Twi (Asante)* (1996) is one book that you may find helpful.

Pronunciation

Twi is generally written in the Latin script, which is also used to write many other languages, including English. There are 26 characters, 24 of which are also found in English.

Twi has 7 vowels, and many of the vowels have several sounds. The various sounds are listed below.

a	‘a’ between apple and calm	i	‘ea’ as in seat
æ	pronounced ‘æ’	o	‘o’ as in go (with i or u)
e	‘a’ as in day (with i or u)	oo	‘oo’ as in book (with ɔ or ε)
ɛ	‘i’ as in sit (with ɔ or ε)	ɔ	‘aw’ as in law
ε	‘e’ as in get	u	‘o’ as in do

The vowels i, e, a, o and u can also be pronounced nasally, by breathing the letter through the nose. In this guide, nasal vowels will be indicated by a tilde (~) over the letter.

Vowels can also be short or long. Short vowels will be indicated by a single letter, while long vowels will be indicated by a double letter (‘a’ vs. ‘aa’).

Generally, Twi consonants are pronounced the same as in English. However, there are several unique sounds.

b	‘b’ as in bat	m	‘m’ as in mill
d	‘d’ as in dog	n	‘n’ as in neat
f	‘f’ as in fun	p	‘p’ as in pin
g	‘g’ as in get	r	‘r’ as in rabbit
		s	‘s’ as in sit
		t	‘t’ as in top
h	‘h’ as in how	w	‘w’ as in wall, but pronounced
k	‘k’ as in kennel		‘yw’ before i, e or ε
l	‘l’ as in last	y	‘y’ as in yolk

dw pronounced 'jw'
 gy 'j' as in judge
 hw 'wh' as in whew
 hy 'sh' as in shirt
 kw 'qu' as in quick

ky 'ch' as in church
 nw pronounced 'nyw'
 ny 'ny' as in canyon
 tw pronounced "chw"

Twi is a tonal language. However, in this guide, tones will not be marked. Tones are best learned by listening to the spoken language. Additionally, you do not need to use tones to be understood.

In some instances, a word's pronunciation will be truncated. In this guide, these truncated pronunciations will follow the word/phrase and be italicized.

Greetings

Welcome	Akwaaba
Come in.	Bra mu.
Knocking.	kɔkɔkɔ
Good morning.	Mema wo akyɛ (<i>maakyɛ</i>)
Good afternoon.	Mema wo ahã (<i>maahã</i>)
Good evening.	Mema wo adwo (<i>maadwo</i>)
Response to older male	Yaa agya
Response to older female	Yaa ɛna
Response, child to adult	Yaa ɔba
Response to peer	Yaa nua (<i>yae ænwĩã</i>)
Goodbye.	Nante yie
Response:	Yoo
Bye.	Kɔ bra.
See you later.	Yɛbɛhyia (<i>yebɛhyia</i>) bio.
How are you?	Wo hɔ te sɛn?
I'm fine.	Me hɔ yɛ.
And you?	Na wo nso ɛ?
How's it going?	ɛte sɛn? or mpɔ mu?

Introductions

My name is...	Wɔfrɛ/Yɛfrɛ me...
What is your name?	Mɛpaakyɛw yɛfrɛ wo sɛn?
I am from America.	Mefi... (<i>mifi</i>)
Where are you from?	Wofi(ri) hɛ?
What are you doing in Ghana?	Woreyɛ (<i>wooyɛ</i>) dɛɛn wɔ Ghana?
I'm a student.	Meyɛ osũãni (<i>oswĩæni</i>)

Etiquette

Thank you	Meda wo ase (<i>medaase</i>)
Thanks	aseda
Please	Mepa wo kyew (<i>mepaakyew</i>)
Sorry	kose
Excuse me (to get attention or to pass)	agoo

Relationships/Titles

I/me	me
You (formal)	wo
He/she/it	ɔno
It (inanimate)	eno
We	yɛn
They	wɛn/wɔɔnom/ɔɔmo
Friend	adamfo
Family	abusũã (<i>æbuswĩã</i>)
Daughter	ɔba baa
Son	ɔba barima (<i>bɛɛma</i>)
Brother	nua
Sister	nua
Father	papa
Mother	maame
Husband	kunu
Wife	yere
Man	ɔbarima
Woman	ɔbaa
Doctor	yaresafoɔ
Teacher	ɔkyerɛkyerɛfo, tikya
Sir/Mr.	Owura
Lady/Ma'am	Awuraa
Slightly Older Male	Brother
Slightly Older Female	Sister
Male your father's age	ɛpanyin
Female your mother's age	ɔbaa panyin
Chief	ɔhene/ɔhema

Food and Drinks

I am hungry.	ɛkɔm de me.
I am thirsty.	Sukɔm de me.
I want...	Mɛpɛ...
Food	aduane
Bread	paanoo
Meat	ɛnam
Fish	nsuomnam

Fruit	duaba
Chicken	akokɔnam
Banana	kwadu (<i>kwædu</i>)
Pineapple	aborɔbɛ
Plantain	borɔdɛɛ
Yam	bayerɛ
Eggs	nkosua
Rice	ɛmo
Stew	frɔɛɛ
Cassava	bankye
Coffee	kɔfe
Tea	tii
Water	nsuo
Alcohol	nsã
Delicious	dɛdɛɛdɛ

Important Locations

Where is it?	ɛhɛ na ɛwɔ? or ɛwɔ hɛ?
Market	edwa
Church	asɔre
Shop	sotɔɔ
School	sukuu
Hospital	ayaresabea
House/Home	fie
Bathroom	adwareɛ
Toilet	tiafi
Kitchen	gyaade
Garden	turo

Cost

How much?	sɛn?
How much is this?	Wei yɛ sɛn?
Money	sika
Price	ɛboɔ
Too much	dodo

Time of Day

Morning	anɔpa
Afternoon	awia
Evening	anwumereɛ
Night	anadwo

Useful Words and Phrases

Yes	aane
No	daabi
Maybe	ebia
Okay	yoo
Now	seesei
Later	akyire yi
What is this?	ɛdeɛn ni?
I want to go...	Mepɛ sɛ mekw...
I am tired.	Brɛ de me.
To be lost	yera
I don't feel good.	Mente apɔɔ.
I am happy.	M'ani asɔ /M'ani agye
I don't understand.	Mente aseɛ
Do you speak English?	Woka borɔfo anaa?
Help!	Mboa
Who?	hena?
Where?	ɛhɛ?
Why?	adɛn?
What?	ɛdeɛn? bɛn?
How?	sɛ nea?

Miscellaneous

Peace	asomdwee
Love	adɔɛ
Work	adwuma
Enough	sɔ̃
Beautiful	fɛ
Slowly	brɛoo/bɔkwɔ
Strength	ahɔɔden
Bad	nyɛ
Good	papa
Overseas	aburokyire
White person	oburoni
Congratulations!	Mo!

Numbers

1	baakõ	11	du baakõ	30	aduasã
2	mmienu	12	du mmienu	40	aduanan
3	mmeensã	13	du mmeensã	50	aduonum
4	ɛnan	14	du nan	60	aduosĩã
5	enum	15	du num	70	aduɔson
6	ensĩã	16	du nsĩã	80	aduɔwɔtwe
7	enson	17	du nson	90	aduɔkron
8	nwɔtwe	18	du nwɔtwe	100	ɔha
9	ɛnkron	19	du nkron	1,000	apem
10	edu	20	aduonu		